

STREAM OF CONSCIOUSNESS (from left) Begum members Dhruv Bhola, Kartik Pillai and Karan Singh

MUSIC

WHEN THREE IS COMPANY

With their third album, the music trio ***Begum*** *hope to have bettered their already novel sound*

Are You Okay?—the title for the upcoming album by Delhi-based experimental indie band Begum—would probably be an accurate question to again ask in 2022. However, for vocalist-guitarist Kartik Pillai, it's something a bit more ineffable. "The themes on this record deal with a feeling of arrest and stillness, random islands, and stolen pencils, mainly a quiet dejection, I think," he says, adding that for Begum, as a band, concepts for the album only really make sense once the songs are completed. "You know how some words sound better on certain chords and, eventually, the melody you have been mumbling into the mic turns into words, and the rhythm you have chanced upon becomes second nature." Begum is all about the stream of consciousness.

Along with Pillai, the band comprises drummer Karan Singh and bassist Dhruv Bhola. Apart from being well-known musicians in the indie scene, the three are also part of Peter Cat Recording Co, a renowned band known for oscillating between various genres, a feature that Begum retains in its own unique way. "We all have varying likes and dislikes, but the common ground we share is in the appreciation of good songwriting and soundscapes. So, that covers all genres—harsh noise and mainstream pop to whatever you can think of," says Pillai.

With *Are You Okay?*, the band will finally be releasing some fresh music after over half a decade. Since its formation in 2013, the band has dropped two albums—*Bagh* (2014) and *W.A.E.* (We Are Excited, 2015). "The first two albums were both recorded over two days and then post-production took its own time. We also recorded in untreated rooms," shares Pillai. With their latest effort, they went in a different direction.

MEMBERS OF BEGUM FIND COMMON GROUND IN APPRECIATION OF GOOD SONGWRITING AND SOUNDSCAPES

"This is our first album since the pandemic, which is why the recording process took a lot longer, but it's also just how we chose to do it this time. We recorded it at my studio in Faridabad, so we were able to home in on a good sound," he says.

The band recently released two dreamy indie rock singles from the album, 'Better Person' and 'Only If You Care'. "I think anyone who listens to 'Better Person' can bring their own meaning to it. I would say it's about unconditional love, the kind you choose and are chosen for," says Pillai.

So, what's next for Begum? A bunch of music videos, the full album release of *Are You Okay?* in March and hopefully a tour soon. "There's going to be 10 songs in total, of which five have music videos so far. Ideally, I just want to keep creating and keep going for as long as possible. Also, we should start recording the next album soon," adds Pillai. ■

–Vijayeta Basu